

FIGHTER AND FIGHTER-BOMBER AIRCRAFT 1943–45

Some combatant nations – notably the Japanese – initially favoured lightweight, lightly armoured fighter aircraft, on the grounds that manoeuvrability was all-important; others preferred better protection and more powerful weaponry, and it was the latter that were to prove more effective. Such fighter aircraft were also more easily adapted to the ground-attack role, and this became increasingly important on both European fronts, and in the Pacific Theatre. After the brief appearance of rocket-powered aircraft, jet propulsion technology took its first faltering steps in aircraft of this type towards the war's end, and within ten years piston-engined fighters had all but disappeared.



▲ REPUBLIC P-47 THUNDERBOLT

Date 1942 **Origin** US
Wingspan 12.42m (40¾ft)
Length 11m (36ft)
Top speed 700kph (435mph)
Engine 1,890.3kW (2,535hp)
 Pratt & Whitney R-2800-59W
 Double Wasp radial

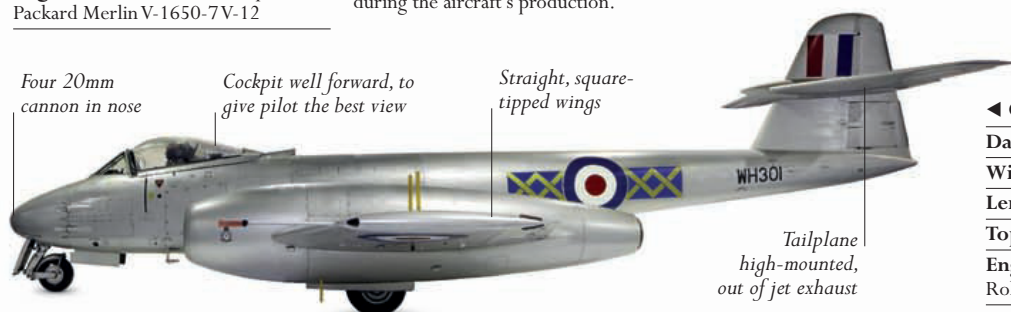
Nicknamed the "Jug" due to its bulky shape, the Thunderbolt was admired for its high-altitude performance – no German aircraft could out-dive it – and its ability to take punishment. It proved extremely effective as a ground-attack fighter-bomber.



▲ NORTH AMERICAN P-51 MUSTANG

Date 1943 **Origin** US
Wingspan 11.3m (37ft)
Length 9.83m (32¼ft)
Top speed 705kph (438mph)
Engine 1,185.6kW (1,590hp)
 Packard Merlin V-1650-7V-12

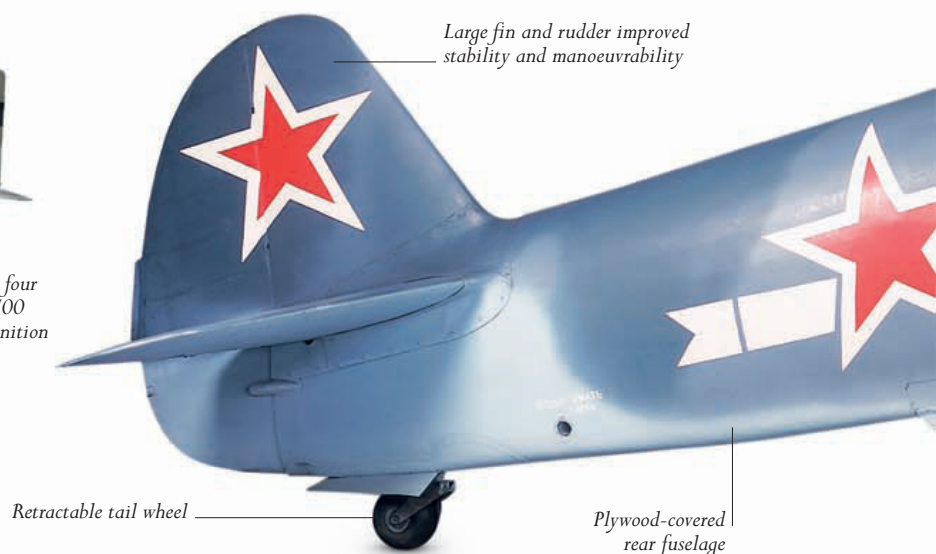
Produced in response to a request from the UK, the Mustang was an underachiever until it was fitted with a Rolls-Royce Merlin engine. It went on to become a mainstay of the US Army Air Forces, both as an escort and as a fighter-bomber. Its rear fuselage and tail were completely redesigned during the aircraft's production.



▲ HAWKER TEMPEST MK II

Date 1944 **Origin** UK
Wingspan 12.5m (41ft)
Length 10.26m (33½ft)
Top speed 695kph (432mph)
Engine 1,931.3kW (2,590hp)
 Bristol Centaurus V radial

The last and best of the British piston-engined fighter aircraft, the Tempest was a fast and manoeuvrable interceptor – capable of taking on the jet-powered Messerschmitts and Arados when deployed intelligently – while also excelling in the ground-attack role.



▲ GLOSTER METEOR

Date 1944 **Origin** UK
Wingspan 11.3m (37¼ft)
Length 13.6m (44½ft)
Top speed 965kph (600mph)
Engine Twin 1,590kg (3,500lb)
 Rolls-Royce Derwent turbojets

The Allies' first operational jet aircraft, the Meteor was the product of a long development programme. It saw active service in World War II and in Korea; its last variant was withdrawn as late as 1965.